

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1160

By Littleton

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Shipp Robbley Weems of Dickson.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Shipp Robbley Weems; and

WHEREAS, Shipp Weems was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, born on March 28, 1948, in Chicago, Illinois, Shipp Robbley Weems followed in the footsteps of his father and grandfather, who were attorneys and judges, and pursued a legal career, becoming the youngest City Judge of record at the age of twenty-nine; and

WHEREAS, in 1986, he initiated the first public defenders program for the State of Tennessee, and based on its success, the State adopted the platform and the Public Defenders' Office was born; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Weems was elected to serve as the 23rd Judicial District Public Defender, which encompassed Cheatham, Dickson, Houston, Humphreys, and Stewart counties, and enjoyed an illustrious tenure in that position over the next decades; and

WHEREAS, he then served as the Assistant Public Defender in Columbia and the surrounding counties until his retirement; he was known by many as "The People's Advocate" for his tireless commitment to ensuring that access to justice did not depend on financial means; and

WHEREAS, in 2025, the Weems-Rezapour Scholarship for Justice and Public Service was established by his daughter, Lara, to honor her father's legacy and lifelong commitment to serving others; and

WHEREAS, Shipp Weems was deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, he enjoyed the loving companionship of his wife of forty years, Beth Jackson Weems, and was the proud father of Sundee (Dennis) Bieker, Stephen (Tina) Weems, Lara Weems-Rezapour (Reza), and his daughter by love, Rachel Weems; grandfather of Lindsay Beth, Jackson Robbley, Alexis Grace, Rosalie Kate, and James Alexander; and step-grandfather of Ella Elizabeth and Natalie Noel; and

WHEREAS, Shipp Weems leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Shipp Robbley Weems, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Mr. Weems.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.